

there than I do living in the same house with you.”

Bud didn't know where to go with the conversation. They had been at this point before. He had wanted to tell Sandi what he was doing and why, but when she took such an offensive position, he just backed off and buried himself in his work. But he couldn't do that now. If he didn't sign over the house as collateral, the bank could call his loans immediately. He would lose everything. Worse than that, he would probably still owe hundreds of thousands of dollars after the properties were sold in this down market. He knew if he could hold on and ride out the bad times, the land values would recover. But right now, the house was the only thing of value he had to pledge. “Listen, Sandi, I know you've been hurt by my actions in the past, but this is a real crisis. If I can't give the banks some additional collateral, they will call the notes on the properties and sell them at cut-rate prices,” Bud said as honestly as he could.

“You still didn't answer my question, Bud. How much do you owe?”

As he started to speak, Bud flinched at what he knew would be a verbal assault from Sandi. “I owe nearly \$800,000,” he said.

And to his utter amazement, he heard Sandi reply, “Well good, then we'll be totally broke when this thing is over, I suspect. I'll be glad to see it all gone.”

“Why?” Bud asked, puzzled.

“Because I've been praying for a long time that something would happen to bring all this to a head. We aren't married; we're just two people living in the same house, sharing the same bed.

“You really don't understand, do you?” she continued, as Bud looked away. “I don't care about the money, the house, or anything money can buy. I would be perfectly satisfied in a three-bedroom house in a simple subdivision with a husband who came home at five o'clock and spent time with his family. Bud, what am I going to do after our kids leave and I'm left here by myself? My mother started drinking because she couldn't stand her life. I don't know what I'd do.”